

Player to watch MARCO JANSEN

Jansen's presence as a world-class all-rounder will be key to South Africa's balance. Since making his ODI debut, he is one of only three fast-bowling all-rounders to have scored at least 400 runs and taken more than 40 wickets — the others being Bas de Leede of the Netherlands and Sompal Kami of Nepal.

The left-arm pacer will take confidence from his impressive performance in the 2023 ODI World Cup, where he played a vital role in South Africa's semifinal run. Now 24, Jansen has firmly established himself as a mainstay across formats. His reliability as a seam-bowling option will also enable South Africa to field two frontline spinners, likely Tabraiz Shamsi and Keshav Maharaj.



formidable, equally adept at consolidation and acceleration. Skipper Temba Bavuma (**above**), Tony de Zorzi, Rassie van der Dussen, and Aiden Markram will anchor the top order.

In Heinrich Klaasen and David Miller, South Africa possesses two of the finest six-hitters in the game, capable of providing a powerful final flourish. Additionally, Tristan Stubbs — whose reputation as a finisher continues to rise in T20 franchise leagues — offers further firepower in the middle order.

Kagiso Rabada, one of the world's top pacers, will lead the bowling attack, bringing a skillset that can dominate all game phases. However, South Africa will be without pace duo Anrich Nortje and Gerald Coetzee, both sidelined due to injury. The Proteas have named 30-year-old Corbin Bosch, who debuted last December, as Nortje's replacement. He has featured in just one ODI and one Test.

One of South Africa's most significant challenges will be

adapting to the unfamiliar conditions in Pakistan. The Proteas last played an ODI in the country in 2007, and their most recent tour, in 2021, featured three T20Is and two Tests.

Pakistan's low-bounce surfaces may neutralise South Africa's traditionally potent pace attack, while its batters must adjust to spin-friendly conditions. To add to their concerns, the Proteas are currently on a four-match losing streak in ODIs, with their last three defeats coming at home against Pakistan.

South Africa will rely on the upcoming Tri-Series against Pakistan and New Zealand to acclimatise to subcontinental conditions ahead of the tournament.

The Proteas are in a tricky Group B alongside Afghanistan, Australia, and England. Their campaign will begin and conclude in Karachi — against Afghanistan and England, respectively — while Rawalpindi will host their crucial encounter against

Australia.

Over the years, South Africa's tendency to falter at pivotal moments has been a defining narrative. However, it is worth remembering that it was the inaugural winner of the Champions Trophy in its original iteration, the ICC Knockouts, in 1998. A repeat triumph would go a long way in dispelling a stereotype of its own making.

SQUAD

Temba Bavuma (c), Tony de Zorzi, Marco Jansen, Heinrich Klaasen, Keshav Maharaj, Aiden Markram, David Miller, Wiaan Mulder, Lungi Ngidi, Kagiso Rabada, Corbin Bosch, Ryan Rickelton, Tabraiz Shamsi, Tristan Stubbs, Rassie van der Dussen